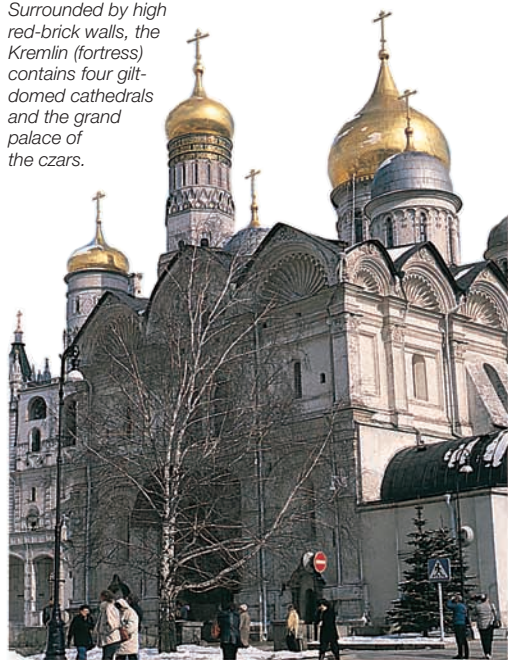


RUSSIAN FEDERATION

STRETCHING ACROSS two continents – Europe and Asia – and extending halfway around the globe, the Russian Federation is by far the largest country in the world. Because of the bitterly cold climate and harsh living conditions, this vast land is sparsely populated. However, Russia has areas of fertile land, rich mineral deposits, and abundant natural resources. The country was once the head of a powerful communist state, the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR). During the collapse of communism in 1991, many parts of the old Soviet Union declared independence. The government of the newly formed Russian Federation is now struggling to establish a Western-style democracy and economy.

Surrounded by high red-brick walls, the Kremlin (fortress) contains four gilt-domed cathedrals and the grand palace of the czars.



POLITICAL CHANGE

The Moscow Kremlin reflects the changing political face of Russia. Once the home of the czars (emperors), who ruled Russia for many centuries, it later became the headquarters of the world's first communist government in 1917. The government created the USSR, which became an industrial and military superpower, but at great cost to its people. The communist state collapsed in 1991, and the Kremlin is now the symbolic home of the new rulers of the Russian Federation.



VOLGA RIVER

The mighty Volga River rises northwest of Moscow and flows 2,193 miles (3,530 km) southward to the Caspian Sea. The Volga is the most important inland waterway in Russia. Hundreds of ships use it every day to transport goods to vast industrial sites that lie alongside the river. Huge dams have created a string of reservoirs providing water and electricity for the people who live on or near its banks.